



PRABHJOT GILL

**THE POWER CENTRE**

**PARTAP SINGH BAJWA**
*Leader of Opposition*

**USP:** A former Punjab Congress chief, he forced the party high command not to ally with the AAP in the state; played crucial role in selecting candidates and formulating campaign strategy

**But:** Still not the undisputed leader of Punjab Congress, which has seen multiple leaders, including two MPs and two MLAs, quit recently

from Kejriwal and his coterie even as the new CM gave a series of contentious statements on sensitive legacy issues like the construction of the Sutlej-Yamuna Link (SYL) canal and the transfer of Chandigarh to Punjab. The state has been facing a leadership crisis in recent years, which has intensified an over-decade-long 'churn'—not just political, but also socio-religious. This is the first election in three decades without two towering personalities visible on the campaign trail—the late Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) patriarch, Parkash Singh Badal, and former chief minister Captain Amarinder Singh, who is hospitalised because of ill health. The impact is being felt across the political spectrum—for Opposition leader and former Punjab Congress chief Partap Singh Bajwa, SAD president Sukhbir Singh Badal, his Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) counterpart Sunil Jakhar and even the helmsmen of smaller Panthic (related to Sikh faith) parties. The election will be a crucial test of their leadership skills, as in addition to winning over the electorate, they have to strengthen their grip over their parties by minimising internal squabbles.

Mann, too, is using this election to reinforce his grip and prove that his assembly election win was no fluke. He talks about free electricity, extension of irrigation facilities and transparency in governance. His rivals point to the poor state of the economy, law and order and the rise of radical elements. The lack of a clear alternative may sustain his government despite its waning popularity, but ground reports from various seats suggest that the AAP legislators are facing anti-incumbency. On May 23, even Mann had to face the wrath of protesting residents at Maur town in Bathinda over the local legislator's "unfulfilled promises". Similar protests have been reported in other seats as well. Mann knows that unfavourable results could very well empower his dissenters and help them regroup. So even if projecting himself as the AAP's face is a big risk, as a party insider tells INDIA TODAY, "it is a risk well worth taking".

## A Solo Fare

The election season in Punjab started with two major announcements—the collapse of alliance talks between the Congress and the AAP in the state and the BJP blocking the return of erstwhile ally SAD to the National Democratic Alliance (NDA). A section of saffron leaders, including Jakhar, was pushing for the SAD-BJP alliance, but the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh wanted the BJP to carve its own space in the state. Meanwhile, it was Bajwa who forced the Congress high command to not ally with the ruling AAP, even as elsewhere—including in capital Chandigarh, neighbouring Haryana and Delhi—the two have fielded joint candidates as part of the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA). This means, for the first time, the state is witnessing a high-stakes quadrangular contest.